were and are logically referred to with the toponymic adjective *Ghuri*; however, a specific kinship-based clan emerged from among them, identified by historical sources as "the house of Shansab" or the Shansabanis.[33] As discussed in Chapter 2 this distinction becomes even more significant over time, as the majority of the Shansabanis' fellow Ghuris most likely did *not* undergo a similar shift in lifeways and economies from varieties of nomadism or transhumance to some degree and type of sedentism (or to empire-building dominance).

To be sure, historical writers such as Minhaj al-Din Siraj Juzjani (AH 589–658/1193–1260 CE) – our principal interlocutor throughout this work (cf. Chapter 1) – referred to the Shansabanis also as "the *malik*s of Ghur," and the appellation has understandably continued in modern Persian- and European-language scholarship.[34] However, in addition to a question of historical discernibility and greater accuracy regarding their politico-military ascendancy as of the mid-twelfth century, using the clan name of "Shansabani" for the protagonists of our story is also historiographically meaningful: To refer to the Shansabanis as "Ghurids" might reify the misinterpretation of their historical impact as limited to their region of origin and – in Barry Flood's term – ephemeral (see above). But as Flood himself rather contradictorily stated, their activities reverberated on "a previously unimaginable scale," so that distinguishing the Shansabanis as such from their fellow Ghuris seems only fitting.[35]

The present Volume's examination of the Shansabanis also provides an entrée into central Afghanistan's nomad–urban continuum, the *more* nomadic aspects of which have historically received less than their merited attention in a wide range of disciplines from history to archaeology and beyond (see Chapter 1). Certainly, the relative paucity of surviving material culture from nomadic societies – or, an alternative characterization could be that methods adequate to recovering these material traces are still coming into focus – has led to fewer studies on the histories of these populations.[36]

The real significance of nomadic groups is increasingly evident, not least because they interacted with *more* sedentist and urban populations to varying degrees, often as "peripatetic traders" supplying desirable commodities and/or labor, and exchanging or purchasing goods within urban and village contexts. Indeed, the seasonal migrations of nomads occasioned regular interactions with the settlements, villages, and towns along their routes of transhumance.[37] Nomads are therefore extremely important in fully grasping the economic and cultural layers of historical towns and cities, which all together shaped the landscape often over centuries.[38] The ensuing analysis attempts to contribute to a recuperation of more of the socio-cultural history of central Afghanistan, relevant both to apprehending the region's historical periods and also to understanding it more fully in modern times.[39]